

Important Child-Protection Terms

Report: An allegation to a state CPS hotline or intake channel typically by any public member who suspects child abuse or neglect happening to the child.

Investigation: The official CPS procedure that follows the acceptance of a report and is used to determine if abuse or neglect has occurred, which typically involves contact with the child, the family and other sources.

Substantiation: A finding following investigation that the evidence meets the state's legal criteria for finding abuse or neglect, with different states using different criteria and terminology, including "substantiated," "founded," "indicated," or similar terms.

Removal: The legal process of removing a child from the home, usually by court order or in an emergency, and placing the child in foster care or another placement due to safety concerns.